João Cercal

Principal Engineer | *Architecting Systems & Empowering People*

I am passionate about creating innovative, scalable solutions that empower people to do what they love. With over 17 years of continuous experience in software engineering, I've evolved from a hands-on developer into a technical leader who architects systems, drives platform reliability, and delivers measurable business impact. I thrive in taking ownership of complex, cross-functional challenges, from re-architecting critical user flows to optimizing cloud infrastructure and strengthening security posture at scale. I've worked with talented individuals worldwide and I am always looking for ways to raise the bar for the teams and systems I work with. ♥

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PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE (MOST RECENT POSITIONS, FULL WORK HISTORY ON LINKEDIN)

Software Engineer Leader · LastPass

Aug 2024 – Present

- Led the re-architecture of the account recovery flow, increasing customer satisfaction (CSAT) by 6% within two months. Coordinated UX researchers, translators, designers, an external vendor (Salesforce), architects, security, product, QAs, release managers, and software engineers to ship a high-visibility project that earned an internal award for its positive impact;
- Took ownership of the Akamai platform project (WAF controls, DNS, traffic reliability and optimization), which had been mismanaged for roughly five years with no clear ownership across the organization. Mapped the status quo, drafted a future-state vision, and earned leadership trust to lead the initiative;
- Delivered ~$500K in year-over-year contract savings through traffic optimization on Akamai, the largest cost saving across the entire platform cluster. Achieved this with a lean team of two engineers plus two outsourced DevOps engineers over six months;
- Awarded Best Culture Representative in the platform cluster and offered an Engineering Manager role in recognition of consistent high-impact leadership, team-building, and stakeholder communication;
- Responsible for team leadership including 1:1s, backlog ownership, refinement, planning, roadmaps, RFCs, ADRs, OpenAPI-driven communication processes, and representing the team technically in all Akamai-related discussions across the organization;
- Driving AI-augmented R&D initiatives to further scale the team's impact while continuing to onboard new projects onto Akamai and maintaining a strong security posture.

Senior Software Engineer · Emma

Mar 2024 – Jul 2024

- Architected, designed, improved, and implemented Emma's technology components, boosting e-commerce performance by developing features in Golang and Java. This led to fast order processing with an event-driven architecture, enhancing the end-to-end purchase process, fewer bugs from better test coverage using testing containers, and streamlined service dependencies, reducing team conflicts;
- Mentored junior developers, conducted code reviews, and fostered continuous learning, resulting in improved code quality, team cohesion, and development efficiency.

Senior PHP Developer · Turbine Kreuzberg — Jul 2022 – Feb 2024

- Making the most of PHP and the Spryker framework/ecosystem to design, develop, and maintain robust e-commerce solutions, ensuring efficient operation of digital platforms;
- Optimizing e-commerce performance through meticulous coding skills and a comprehensive understanding of the Spryker framework, which directly leads to enhanced user experiences, faster page load times, and increased conversion rates for our clients;
- Collaboratively solving complex challenges within our agile development environment, actively collaborating with cross-functional teams to tackle intricate challenges, utilizing problem-solving skills and technical expertise to create innovative solutions that drive the success of our large-scale e-commerce projects.

Senior Software Engineer · Spectrm — Aug 2020 – Jun 2022

- Making a significant impact on the market by helping top-tier companies engage consumers effectively through innovative chatbots on major messaging platforms. This resulted in substantial sales growth and strengthened brand loyalty;
- By designing, developing, and launching scalable solutions to tackle intricate business challenges, with a lasting focus on scalability, I significantly improved operational efficiency, expanded the company's market presence, and ensured long-term adaptability, driving the business to new heights;
- Led backend chapter meetings, mentored junior developers, and played a crucial role in defining migration strategies for essential platform changes;
- Introduced architectural decision records (ADRs), conducted post-mortems, and facilitated lightning talks to promote a culture of continuous improvement within the engineering team.

Senior PHP Developer · GetYourGuide — Dec 2018 – Jul 2020

- Impacting and changing the way how millions of travelers connect to the places they visit, using weekends, building relationships, visiting relatives, and discovering the world;
- Aligning the product with technical decisions while having the customer at first, but also considering data over guessing have guided me to influence in a killer feature to contact us through WhatsApp in which our travelers can get support from their smartphones. It increased the second customer purchase metric considerably and helped us to retain customers;
- Test-driven oriented, impacting the way that engineers see unit test bringing then, the quality of the product to the next level.

SKILLS

PHP · GO